

Pins restrict useful movement

Thinking And Training

THE IDEA

A pinned piece stands between an attacker and a more important target. An absolute pin to the king makes exposing that king illegal. A relative pin, such as to a queen, may be broken if the resulting counterplay justifies the loss.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A knight pinned to its king may appear to defend a nearby square but be unable to capture there. A knight pinned to a queen could still jump with check, forcing the opponent to respond before taking the queen.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What is the first distinction to make when you see a pin?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Is the rear target the king or another piece? Then check whether the pinned piece can move along the line, capture the attacker, or create a stronger threat.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

A pin changes legal or practical options; identify which.